This is how the air forces of India's main adversaries, China and Pakistan, stack up against the IAF



PAKISTAN

- **Fighter jets (No.: 453)** Chinese-made **J-7**, JF-17, J-10, French Mirage 5EF, Mirage III EP, US-made F16
- **Transport fleet (28):** C-130B, Saab 2000, CN 235, Y 12, IL-78
- **AWACS & AEW&C (13):** Y-8, Falcon DA-20 and Super King Air
- **Helicopters (35):** AW 139 and SE 160, **Mil-171** transport helicopter, medium utility Bell 205 and Bell 412 copters, Bell H1 Cobra attack helicopter
- **UAVs (10):** Chinese Caihong 4, Wing Loong, Turkish Bayraktar Akinci

INDIA

- **Fighter jets (No.: 632)** Rafale, Su-30 MKI, LCA Tejas, Mirage 2000, Jaguar, Mig-29, Mig-21 Bison
- **Transport fleet (250):** C-17 III, C-130J-30, Ilyushin IL-76, Antonov AN-32, Dornier DO 228
- **AWACS & AEW&C (14):** Gulfstream, A50E, Embraers
- **Helicopters (438):** AH-64E Apache, LCH Prachand, ALH Rudra, CH-47F Chinook, MI-26, MI-8, MI-17, MI-17IV, MI-17 V5
- **UAVs (198):** Israeli-made Searcher II, Heron



WELCOME, BIG BIRD Defence minister Rajnath Singh at the induction of the C-295 at Hindon air force station near Delhi

ANI

air and fly eight to 10-hour missions. It is in a position to dominate from Malacca Strait to the Gulf of Aden," says Air Marshal Anil Chopra (retd).

IAF VS PLAAF, PAF

A recent report by the US Department of Defense points out that the Chinese are developing their H-20 stealth bomber, projected to have nuclear and conventional roles. It also notes the arrival of the new Y-20U aerial tanker, which will expand the PLAAF's ability to conduct long-range operations.

Military observers say that though the PLAAF enjoys a numerical advantage, it is hampered by low combat experience. Most Chinese fighters are a result of reverse-engineering, making them less reliable than the Western aircraft that IAF operates. As former IAF chief Dhanoa said, "If Chinese equipment was so good, why did the Pakistanis use F-16s in the Rajouri sector a day after the Balakot strike?"

However, it cannot be discounted that the PLAAF is the third largest air force in the world, with nearly 1,700 combat aircraft, of which nearly 800 are fourth generation-plus jets. It also operates around 150 J20 fifth generation stealth jets. Its H-6 bomber can carry six air-launched cruise missiles. Also, it has over 50 Y-20 heavy transport aircraft and a variety of flight refueller and AEW&C aircraft in its inventory. The PLAAF has indigenous and Russian utility and attack helicopters and a large number of UAVs.

Besides, it has a large number of aerial precision munitions, including long-range BVR missiles like the PL-12 and PL-21. China has a significant inventory of land attack cruise missiles with a 1,500 km range. The PLAAF operates the Russian S-300 and S-400 systems, and the domestically produced HQ-9 air defence systems.

However, the PLAAF's stealth, electronic warfare and avionics technologies are far behind international standards. "The Rafale is superior to China's J-10, J-11 and Su-27 fighter jets. Only the Su-35S and J-20 will perhaps compete with the IAF's Sukhoi Su-30MKI. Our Mirage 2000s and MiG-29s have all been upgraded," Chopra adds.

Not just a tactical advantage, Indian officials point out that China has 11 airfields facing India in Tibet and Xinjiang, with most situated at over 10,000 feet. In comparison, the IAF has around 25 airfields facing China, a majority of which are at below 2,000 feet, thus being advantageous in terms of load carriage and the number of missions they can launch.

And what of the threat from our other adversary, Pakistan? IAF officials say that though the PAF operates fewer aircraft, it has considerably modernised its force. With nearly 75 American F-16 fighter jets, 25 Chinese fourth generation J-10Cs and 150 multi-role JF-17s, as well as operational exposure in exercises, they remain a significant force.

While the IAF has been modernising steadily, more needs to be done. The authorised level of 42 squadrons of fighters must be achieved. Some strategists are confident about India's advantage, pointing to the greater efficacy of the Rafale and the Su-30MKI. Chopra disagrees: "The argument is flawed. India's adversaries have fifth generation fighters. And they are not cutting down on numbers." The IAF has indeed come a long way, but it can hardly rest on its newly won laurels. ■